

PHYSICAL CARE

1. Infection Control

The reason for infection control is that anyone may carry any number of bacteria (germs). Therefore, the rules of precaution apply to everyone. Universal precautions protect you and the person you are caring for from infection.

Handwashing

Washing your hands is the most effective way to prevent spread of infections. Wash with warm soapy water before and after every contact with the person you are caring for. Prevent dryness and chapping with hand lotion and keep your cuticles and nails trimmed so your hands are easy to keep clean.

Garbage disposal

All dirty dressings or other used, disposable products with blood or body fluids on them must be inside two plastic bags for disposal. This is intended to keep all of the bacteria contained within the bags so they will not spread infection.

Gloves

Disposable latex or vinyl gloves should be worn for handling objects which have blood or body fluids on them. Disposable gloves should never be reused and should be put in the two plastic bags in the garbage.

Aprons

Wear a disposable plastic apron if your clothes are likely to be soiled while you give care. Place the apron in the two plastic bags in the garbage when you take it off.

Masks

Wear a mask if you have a cold. You can protect yourself with a mask when the person you are caring for is coughing a lot. Ask your home care nurse how to use the mask properly.

Needles and syringes

Place used needles and syringes in a hard plastic or metal container that has a lid. Place the lid on the container when it is full and tape it shut so the needles will not fall out and stick anyone. The

procedure for disposal varies across the province so ask your home care nurse how it is done in your community.

Food preparation

Raw foods are prime carriers of germs. Meats and eggs should be cooked thoroughly. Fruits and vegetables should always be washed before you cook or eat them. Wash dishes, glassware and cooking utensils in hot, soapy water. If you use a cutting board to prepare raw meat, always wash the board in hot water before you use it again.

Pets

Since animals can carry disease, it is important to make sure that family pets are healthy and up-to-date for check-ups or shots. Make sure you wash your hands thoroughly after you clean the cat's litter box or the bird's cage.

2. Bathing

Bathing is an important part of personal care and offers both physical and emotional comfort.

How you can offer care

- Someone who is strong enough and able to move about can be helped to wash in a shower, bath tub, or at the sink.
- Put a bath chair on a non-slip mat in the tub or shower if getting in and out or standing for a long time is difficult. A chair at the sink can also be used if this seems to work better.
- Equipment such as bars for holding, non-slip surfaces and bath lifts may be helpful.
- Gather all the things you will need before helping the person into the bathroom:
 - clean clothes or pyjamas
 - soap and shampoo
 - face cloth
 - towel
 - lotion
- Test the water temperature of the bath or shower.
- Help the person get into the bath or shower.
- Allow the person to wash as much as possible. You may need to help with the back, legs, feet and genital area.

- Offer assistance out of the bath or shower and help to dry. A towel put in the drier for a few minutes before it is needed can provide added warmth.
- Help the person into clean clothes.

BED BATH

Fig 1. The procedure: bed bathing a patient



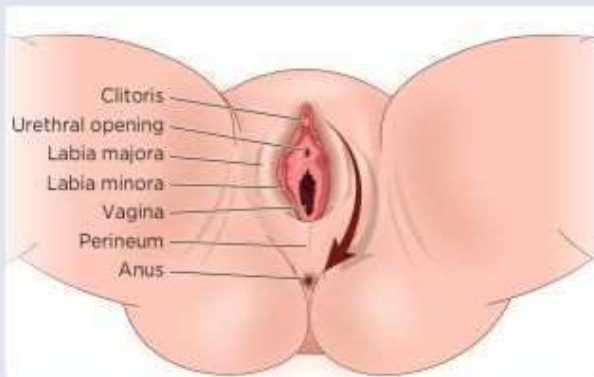
1a. Place a towel under the patient's chin. Wash their eyes, face, neck and ears, check whether they like soap on their face



1b. Starting with the arm farthest away, wash and dry the top half of the body. Only expose the part of the body being washed



1c. Patients may enjoy soaking their hands and feet in a bowl of water placed on the bed



1d. Wash the genital area of female patients from front to back to reduce the risk of urinary tract infection



1e. Wash the patient's back and sacrum, moving from top to bottom

Someone who must stay in bed will benefit from a bed bath every day. As well as providing cleanliness, it helps refresh your loved one and gives you the chance to talk and listen.

How you can offer care

Although a bed bath can be given at any time, often people who are ill have more energy in the morning. Ask the person what time would be best.

- Provide privacy.
- Gather the things you will need:
 - large bowl with warm water
 - soap
 - wash cloth and towels
 - light bed cover
 - lotion
- Raise the level of the bed if this is possible to lessen the strain on your back.
- Cover the person with a light cover for warmth and only uncover and wash one part of the body at a time.
- Use a gentle soap on the skin, then rinse and dry.
- Start at the face and work down towards the feet.
- Apply lotion if desired after drying an area.
- Wash front and sides first, then help the person to lie on one side while you wash the back.
- Wash the genital and anal areas last. It is important that these areas be cleaned well at least daily as bacteria tend to collect there. Wash between the person's legs from the front toward the back. Rinse well.
- Apply a water-repellent cream (e.g. Penaten Cream™, Zincofax™, A&D Cream™) to the genital area if incontinence is a problem.
- Change the water as often as necessary to keep it clean and hot.
- Wash the person's face, hands, back, underarms and genitals daily if a complete bath is too tiring.
- Apply lotion to all pressure areas. Also, while you are using the lotion, the person may appreciate a complete back rub.
- Change soiled or wet sheets after the bed bath is finished.
- Remember shaving, make-up and brushing and styling hair are important parts of care and will help the person feel more comfortable. Often a rest before and after these activities will help prevent the person from becoming over-tired.

3. Mouth Care

Cleaning a person's mouth is not difficult. By helping a patient have a clean mouth you will increase comfort, prevent mouth sores and maybe improve appetite.

How you can offer care

Brushing teeth

- Help the person into a sitting position. If it is more comfortable, or if the person cannot sit, help lift the head.
- Place a dry towel under the chin.
- Give the person a sip of water to moisten the inside of the mouth.
- Use an ultra-soft toothbrush and soften the bristles in hot water.
- Do not use toothpaste as it can be harsh on fragile gum tissue. Moisten the brush in one of the rinsing solutions suggested later in this section under Rinsing.
- Brush the teeth using gentle strokes starting at the gum line and moving to the edge of the teeth.
- Brush the cheeks, gums and tongue gently.
- Do not put the toothbrush too near the back of the throat as this may cause gagging.
- Try to remove all food particles and crusted material.
- Have the person rinse with cool water and spit into the bowl or basin.
- If the person is unconscious, use a soft toothbrush moistened in one of the rinsing solutions. Gently rub along the teeth, gums and tongue.

Denture care

- If the person has dentures, remove these and clean them with a toothbrush.
- Do not use very hot water on dentures as they may warp.
- Do not soak dentures in bleach as this may damage them. Any commercially available product marketed for denture soaking may be used.
- If the gums are dry under dentures, a product such as Oral Balance™ may provide comfort.
- If dentures are loose or poor fitting, they may cause mouth sores. Have them refitted by a dentist or, if this is not possible, leave them out except when eating?

Lip care

- Put a water-soluble lubricant such as K-Y Jelly™, Muco™ or Dermabase™ on the lips.
- Avoid using oil-based products such as Vaseline™, Chapstick™ and mineral oil. These may make open sores on the lips more inflamed. Also, if a person is unconscious, an oil-based product may be breathed into the lungs and cause pneumonia.

Rinsing

- Rinsing the mouth is not a substitute for brushing.
- If the person is not able to get out of bed, the mouth should be rinsed every two hours at the same time you do skin care. For an unconscious person, wipe the mouth with a gauze dipped in a rinsing solution.
- Use a non-alcohol based rinsing solution. Suggestions include:
 - baking soda (1 teaspoon) and water (2 cups)
 - salt (1/2 teaspoon), baking soda (1 teaspoon) and water (4 cups)
 - club soda
- Avoid over-the-counter mouthwashes that contain alcohol. The alcohol can make mouth tissues dry and increase the risk of infection.

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